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FURTHER READING

Anthologies containing relevant work include Lucie-Smith's *British Poetry Since 1945* (1985), Allnut's *The New British Poetry 1968-1988* (1988) and Crozier and Longville's *A Various Art* (1987). For a contemporary collection Horovitz (1969) is still useful, while Nuttall (1970) is an impassioned inside account of the social and literary underground. I have been greatly indebted to Crozier (1983) for my analysis of the Movement, but for a general account see also Morrison (1980). Davie (1973) is unavoidable for strength of argument on behalf of the orthodoxy. Alternative poetries and poetics are, as yet, not so coherently surveyed. Raban's *The Society of the Poem* (1971) outlines the confusing variety of poetry appearing in the late 1960s. Thurley's *The Ironic Harvest* (1974) is an eccentric account of twentieth-century British poetry, but his final chapter deals with Lee Harwood and Mark Hyatt as well as the Liverpool poets. Weatherhead's *The British Dissonance* (1983) offers an explication of British poetry of the 1960s and 1970s outside the Movement orthodoxy, including Fisher and Harwood; it is recommended as an introduction to the poetics of indeterminacy. Cobbing and Mayer (1978) is an invaluable source book of concrete poetry, and Mayer (1974) itemizes Cobbing's contribution to it.

Chapter 9

The return of the repressed: Gothic and the 1960s novel

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INTRODUCTION

There are a number of obvious developments in the British novel of the 1960s through which the concept of 'cultural revolution' could be explored. For instance, in the early part of the decade especially, a distinctive group of writers – including Storey, Barstow and Williams – built on the foundation provided by Sillitoe and Braine in the late 1950s to provide challenging explorations of the changing identities of class.¹ Of equal note was the tentative emergence of a new aesthetic in women's writing, prompted by increasing mobilization round issues of gender – of which Doris Lessing's *The Golden Notebook* (1962) is the prototype. However, such writing only gathers momentum at the end of the decade. Fresh kinds of 'experimental' writing also began to appear, providing a radical challenge to established narrative conventions and, more debatably, to the social assumptions supporting them.² B. S. Johnson was possibly the most interesting domestic writer attempting to reorient the genre in light of reconsiderations of modernism and experiments abroad such as the *nouveau roman*.

But perhaps the most significant development was a sharply accelerated cross-fertilization between 'popular' and 'serious' narrative forms in the 1960s. As the dominant postwar mode of neo-realism, favoured by figures like Snow, Cooper and Wain, came increasingly to be seen as a dead-end, a number of writers looked to 'popular' narrative as a way of re-animating an apparently atrophying genre. Science fiction received serious critical attention with Kingsley Amis's *New Maps of Hell* (1960), and achieved new audiences and levels of excellence through the work of figures like Brian Aldiss, Michael Moorcock and J. G. Ballard. The genre also

provided fresh inspiration for 'mainstream' novelists. Anthony Burgess abandoned the realism of *The Malayan Trilogy* (1956–9) for science fiction in *A Clockwork Orange* (1962) and *The Wanting Seed* (1962), and there is a steadily developing interest in the genre between the early novels of Doris Lessing and her later work, beginning with *The Four-Gated City* (1969). And while Fowles's *The French Lieutenant's Woman* (1969) is usually considered a reworking of historical romance through the prism of the *nouveau roman*, Waugh (1984) points out the narrator's description of it as a science fiction journey back in time (123).

But science fiction was not the only 'popular form' seen to contain such potential. Amis's *The James Bond Dossier* (1965) made large claims for spy fiction. While his *Colonel Sun* (1968) does not, perhaps, fully substantiate his case, the genre was transformed into an instrument of penetrating social criticism by Len Deighton's *The Ipcress File* (1962) and John Le Carré's *The Spy Who Came in from the Cold* (1963). And Le Carré gave a similar new direction to the detective novel in *A Murder of Quality* (1962).

Gothic is one instance of this process of cross-fertilization that has received insufficient attention.³ For example, the genre is absent from the list provided by Waugh of the 'popular' forms that excited the interest of 'serious' writers in the new decade (Waugh 1984: 86). While critical studies of Gothic have proliferated recently, their focus has usually been on its romantic and modernist phases, and this volume provides an opportunity to consider its resurgence in the 1960s. Many of the problems addressed by 1960s Gothic, including violence, gender politics, sexuality and culture's role as an instrument of social control and discrimination, are connected with some of the wider issues at the centre of political and cultural debate – and indeed are still very much alive. Moreover, since Gothic re-emerged as a serious literary resource in the 1960s, an increasing number of British writers, including Carter, Bainbridge, Weldon, Tennant, Martin Amis, Sinclair, McEwan and Ackroyd, have used its conventions with varying degrees of emphasis.

Between the modernists (James and Conrad experimented with the mode, and Virginia Woolf wrote sympathetically about it) and the 1960s, Gothic lost much of its appeal for the modern novelist, with the notable exception of Mervyn Peake. (Though elements remain in Lowry, Henry Green and Evelyn Waugh.) None the less, Gothic continued to thrive as a 'popular' mode in the postwar era, taking forms as diverse as the 'horror' fiction of bestsellers like

Dennis Wheatley and, above all, cinema. *The Hammer House of Horror* series began in 1957, inspired by the success of Hollywood Gothic in the 1930s, and versions of the Dracula and Frankenstein stories helped Hammer become one of the most successful British film houses over the next 20 years. With *Psycho* (1963) and *The Birds* (1963), moreover, Hitchcock demonstrated that 'horror' retained the potential for psychological investigations of considerable power.⁴

Since little work has been done on modern British Gothic,⁵ it is first necessary to establish that the mode did indeed make a return in the 1960s, before proceeding to consider the cultural/political implications of its renaissance. In this chapter it will only be possible to look at the work of Iris Murdoch, John Fowles and Muriel Spark in even superficial detail. But one should be aware of the wider range of work centrally influenced by Gothic in the decade. These include Colin Wilson's *Ritual in the Dark* (1960) and *Adrift in Soho* (1961); David Storey's *Radcliffe* (1963) (the title invokes one of the great figures of romantic Gothic, and Storey also wrote a screenplay of *Wuthering Heights*); and Jean Rhys's retelling of *Jane Eyre* to include the first Mrs Rochester's point of view, in *Wide Sargasso Sea* (1966). The end of the decade brought J. G. Farrell's *Troubles* (1970) and Angela Carter's emergence as a dominant figure in contemporary Gothic with *The Magic Toyshop* (1967) and *Heroes and Villains* (1969).

However, Fowles's first two novels, much of Spark's fiction from *The Comforters* (1957) to *The Hothouse by the East River* (1973) and most of Murdoch's output between *A Severed Head* (1961) and *The Nice and The Good* (1968) constitute the major evidence of a return to Gothic in the decade. While some of these novels have already been identified as having Gothic elements – for instance *The Unicorn*, by Scholes (1967: 106); *The Prime of Miss Jean Brodie* and *The Driver's Seat*, by Stevenson (1986: 184–5); and *The Magus*, by Kane (1988: 120ff) – this body of work is usually considered as responding to foreign influences such as the French existential novel and/or the *nouveau roman*.

These writers were undoubtedly aware of continental developments. *The French Lieutenant's Woman* (1969), for instance, refers to Barthes and Robbe-Grillet (85). Even this novel, however, has strong Gothic elements; the model for Sarah's elusive 'double' identity is *Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde*, which is identified as 'the best guidebook to the age' (319). And the preface to the revised edition of *The Magus* (1977) acknowledges no debt to French contemporaries. Similarly,

Stevenson's concentration on links between Spark's *The Comforters* and the *nouveau roman* (1986: 182–3) ignores her considerable research on the Brontës and Mary Shelley in the 1950s. In *The Mandelbaum Gate* (1965), the protagonist Barbara Vaughan, at least, is antagonistic towards the *nouveau roman* (177). In 'The sublime and beautiful revisited' (1959) Iris Murdoch's praise for Emily Brontë, Hawthorne, Melville and Dostoevsky, 'to whom we would not want to deny a first place' (258), is recognition of the achievement of a marginalized tradition that she herself was to explore in the next decade. (Murdoch's title echoes not just Kant, but Burke, whose *Inquiry into the Sublime and Beautiful* (1756) facilitated the emergence of the original Gothic aesthetic, in reaction to the Augustan values of order, harmony and clarity. These, interestingly, were often invoked nostalgically by postwar neo-realists like Cooper, Amis and Wain, whose main critical interests and narrative models lay in the eighteenth century.)

In any case, many of the novels in question link themselves on a variety of levels with Gothic precursors. For all three writers, James's *The Turn of the Screw* is an important point of reference. In Murdoch's *The Italian Girl* (1964), for instance, the narrator at first idealizes the ambiguous Flora in a manner that recalls the governess's initial response to her identically named charge. The revised edition of the *Magus* (1977) acknowledges the inspiration of James's tale (5), and in Muriel Spark's *The Public Image* (1968) Frederick works on a script that reminds Annabel Christopher of the novella. An equally important source is Charlotte Brontë. The reviewers describe Spark's Annabel as 'a twentieth-century Jane Eyre' (20), and the fires in Murdoch's *The Italian Girl*, Storey's *Radcliffe* and Carter's *The Magic Toyshop* all owe something to Brontë's novel. Individual works have more specific affiliations. For instance, the ominous opening of Murdoch's *The Unicorn* recalls Harker's approach to the Count's castle in *Dracula*, and a series of scenes link Hannah Crean-Smith to Dracula himself (40, 219). Similarly, Murdoch's *The Time of the Angels* (1966) recalls M. G. Lewis's *The Monk*, with its focus on a demonic priest involved in incest with a relative whom he has imprisoned. Spark's *The Ballad of Peckham Rye* (1960) echoes *Confessions of a Justified Sinner* by Spark's fellow Scottish writer James Hogg; like Gilmartin, Dougal Douglas is a 'diabolical agent' (81) who has the power to change appearance at will.

At the level of motif, too, these novels reveal their generic lineage.

The Unicorn and *The Magus* involve governess figures (or their male equivalents) who are made to confront the limitations of their self-knowledge. Both Fowles novels and Carter's *The Magic Toyshop* are centred on orphans. 'Mad' figures appear in Storey's *Radcliffe*, Murdoch's *The Italian Girl* and Spark's *Not to Disturb*. The architectural tropes of earlier Gothic return, including Chateau Klopstock in *Not to Disturb*, Beaumont in *Radcliffe* and Gaze mansion in *The Unicorn*. Even the more modest buildings in Murdoch's *The Time of the Angels* or Fowles's *The Collector* (built in 1625) have isolated claustrophobic settings and rooms that function as dungeons. Suspense and horror, so characteristic of earlier Gothic, are heightened in its contemporary equivalent by similar plot conventions, including kidnap (*The Magus* and *The Collector*) and imprisonment – mental as well as physical (both Fowles novels, *The Unicorn*, *The Time of the Angels*). Finally, as in romantic Gothic, violence of manifold kinds and sexual 'deviancy', including incest, voyeurism and sado-masochism recur throughout the trio's work.

But there are important differences, too, between contemporary Gothic and its earlier forms. Modern Gothic usually has a surface realism that allows the reader to suspend disbelief in the face of apparently extreme events and situations. It tends to 'domesticate' many of the genre's established conventions, so that the settings are distanced in time or space only vestigially or symbolically. While *The Unicorn* is set amongst 'the gentry' (11), as is Spark's *Not to Disturb*, most 1960s Gothic prefers a more ordinary social milieu than the religious orders or aristocracy favoured by romantic Gothic. Most obviously, except in the case of Spark, the supernatural aspect of earlier Gothic disappears; ghosts, vampires and monsters survive only metaphorically, within a psychologically realistic framework. Possession, for instance, is transformed into obsession. Thus, in *The Italian Girl*, the 'Gothic' Otto (34), with his bestial appetites and 'exceptional physical strength' (39), behaves 'monstrously' without ever threatening to become superhuman. The 'domestication' of modern Gothic relates to one of its most important insights, that the everyday and the 'normal' may be sources of horror and terror quite as potent as anything conceived of by earlier Gothic. In its contemporary variant, domestic violence can be as sickening as any of the torture scenes in romantic Gothic; an apparently innocuous neighbour or friend may become a 'monster'; and family and friends can be emotional vampires.

ATROPHY OR INNOVATION?

As a broad generalization, the 1960s have usually been seen as a period in which the British novel was unable to match the range and quality of writers in Europe and America, or even the Third World. Bergonzi (1970) argues powerfully that it was, by and large, formally conservative and preoccupied with relatively mundane local themes. Alter (1975), Scholes and Waugh argue that experimentation with the genre was notably lacking in Britain. Despite the efforts of Bradbury and Palmer (1979) and Stevenson, such pessimism about the achievement of the 1960s has persisted. Patrick Swinden's essay (1989) is particularly scathing; like Bergonzi, he sees 'cultural decline' (277) in the decade as symptomatic of wider decay. (The comment that 'Britain's economic power was being sapped by the insidious demands of a parasitic social democracy' (254) indicates the political affiliations of his argument.) Swinden particularly deplores the turn to 'popular' culture, concluding that it only 'exerted a pressure towards the juvenile, the irresponsible' (263). Lamenting the demise of the 'elegant' (a recurrent buzzword) social comedy favoured by Pym, Powell and Amis, Swinden asserts that the British novel of the 1960s, 'by seeking to be earnest and relevant . . . ceased to be serious without being comic' (270). Swinden is able to construct his hostile image of the decade only by studiously avoiding much of its characteristic literature; he concentrates instead on 'old hands, trained in the pre-1960s schools of common-sense realism and respect for their craft' (283). He overlooks 'experimental' writing, ignores Fowles and Spark (and Lessing) completely and complains that Murdoch was 'pouring out unnecessary and uninspiring novels at the rate of one a year throughout the 1960s' (279).

Swinden's essay provides a useful opportunity to reconsider the nature and quality of the British novel in the 1960s. Far from agreeing that it entered a state of atrophy or decadence, I would suggest that the turn to 'popular' narrative forms helped lay the foundations for a major revival in the fortunes of the domestic novel in the subsequent two decades. Moreover, I would argue that 1960s Gothic can legitimately be seen as a local version of the technical innovations that earned such praise for the new European and American novel in this period and constitute an equally radical challenge to dominant novelistic practice in Britain between 1945 and 1960.

Contemporary 'experimental' fiction is characterized most obviously by its formal self-consciousness, the foregrounding of convention to stress its fictionality. This problematizes the relationship between language and its referents and, more broadly, between the conventions of representation and 'reality'. In this sense, 'experimentalism' may be understood as a symptom of what Bergonzi describes as the era's 'pathological uncertainty about the nature of reality' (198). An increasing sense of the strangeness of the contemporary world and the breakdown of consensually determined definitions of 'reality' led many 'experimentalists' to see it sceptically as, at best, a 'collective fiction, constructed and sustained by the processes of socialization, institutionalization, and everyday social interaction, especially through the medium of language' (McHale 1987: 37).

But 1960s Gothic, too, is beset by the ontological doubt that McHale sees as 'the dominant' of 'experimentalism'. In *The Unicorn*, for example, the play with binoculars, mirrors, and the name 'Gaze' draws attention to Murdoch's exploration of how far subjective vision constructs reality, particularly the identity of others. *The Magus* centres on the struggle of Urfe (and the reader) to separate illusion from 'reality', and in *The Ballad of Peckham Rye* Douglas's metamorphoses make other characters (and the reader) 'hesitate' between natural and supernatural explanations of his identity. As in earlier periods, hallucination, nightmare and paranoia stalk the protagonists of contemporary Gothic, emphasizing the unstable and elusive nature of the boundaries between subjective and objective reality.

Self-consciousness is manifested at another level in the number of artist figures in 1960s Gothic, including the (failing) poet Urfe in *The Magus*, and the sculptor Alexander in Murdoch's *A Severed Head*, whose comments on the problems of rendering personality reflect on Murdoch's own preoccupations with construction of character in the novel. Spark's fiction contains many artist protagonists; in *The Comforters*, most obviously, Caroline researches 'Form in the Modern Novel' and records her 'difficulty with the chapter on realism' (57). Moreover, the characteristic avoidance of intrusive omniscient narrative often shifts responsibility (on one level) from the author to a narrating character who has to wrestle with the problems of shaping the structure of his/her story and elucidating its significance. Urfe in *The Magus* (which at a different level is about another storyteller, Conchis), and Lynch-Gibbon in *A Severed*

Head, are obvious examples. The Prospero-like Lister in Spark's *Not to Disturb* is a variation on this trope.

Indeed, most of the techniques used by 'experimental' fiction to foreground its problematic relations to 'reality' are also found in 1960s Gothic. Thus, in keeping with Murdoch's dictum that good texts 'provide lucid commentaries on themselves' (cited in Conradi 1986: 121), it flaunts its intertextual relations with earlier phases of the genre, as noted earlier. Language is consistently foregrounded as constructive rather than simply reflective of 'reality'. This is one function of Spark's use of bizarre metaphor; *Not to Disturb* describes lightning as 'like a zip-fastener ripped from its garment by a sexual maniac' (86), and in *The Comforters* there is 'a silence so still you could hear a moth breathe' (127). Murdoch's perception of language's arbitrary and conventional qualities is dramatized in her use of 'empty' symbols that fracture conventional notions of linguistic transparency. An example is the unicorn in the novel of that name. Conjuring up a creature that does not exist, the symbol fails to 'match' its referent. Max's description of Hannah in terms of medieval associations of the unicorn with Christ obscures as much as it clarifies. To see Hannah simply as suffering redeemer ignores her antithetical role as would-be murderess and her associations with Dracula.

While 1960s Gothic characteristically follows generic precedent in its emphasis on suspense, it also plays with conventions of plot in the manner of contemporary 'experimental' fiction. In *The Driver's Seat*, Spark subverts the reader's expectations of murder mystery by revealing the denouement early on, in order to concentrate attention on how the events leading up to Lise's death are organized. Similarly, Murdoch sometimes provides a whole series of 'turns of the screw' to her plots, in a deliberate challenge to conventional realist notions of probability. In *The Unicorn* this is done with particular emphasis. Two-thirds of the way through, Marian comments 'It was like a comedy by Shakespeare. All the ends of the story were being bound up in a good way' (208). But the seven major twists that follow serve to deconstruct the conventional purposes of plot; it is revealed as, above all, a device habitually producing consolatory resolutions and containments that *The Unicorn* itself studiously resists.

A further parallel between 1960s Gothic and 'experimental' fiction lies in their conception of character and the problems posed in its representation. Unlike neo-realism, which generally sees charac-

ter as psychologically 'legible' and morally definable, modern Gothic portrays human personality as contradictory, fragmented and elusive on both levels. Murdoch's 1960s novels embody much of the argument of her seminal essay of 1961, 'Against dryness', in which she called for a renewed recognition of the 'opacity of persons', as against realism's 'consoling myth' of its accessibility and clarity (30). Spark's novels consistently dramatize the radical oddness and mystery of seemingly average people like Georgina Hogg in *The Comforters*. To some degree, the ambivalence of characters like Gerald Scottow in *The Unicorn* is reminiscent of the Byronic villains of romantic Gothic, who are at once repulsive and attractive. But Honor Klein, Dougal Douglas and Conchis are more radically contradictory characters, supporting interpretations that are mutually irreconcilable and establishing a plurality of meaning that is finally impossible to stabilize.

This manoeuvring towards a more 'realistic' (but anti-realist) conception of character is paradoxically accompanied by a self-conscious display of the fictionality of even this new paradigm. In 1960s Gothic, characters are often aware of themselves as actors/actresses in a plot they do not control. This cannot simply be seen as a psychologically credible response to their situation, nor is it merely expressive of their creators' characteristic rejection of the more extreme versions of existential voluntarism. Their self-awareness draws the reader's attention to their status as linguistic constructions, effects of textual practice, in a manner that corresponds to play with the 'absence' of character in 'experimental' fiction. In *The Unicorn*, for instance, an insistent pattern highlighting characters' awareness of 'role' serves to undermine the illusion of realism encouraged by the surface texture of Murdoch's prose. Early in the novel, for example, Marian has a revelation: 'Her own place in the story occurred to her for the first time. The ghastly tale had become a reality. . . . And it was a tale in which nothing happened at random' (64). In *The Comforters*, Spark achieves similar effects when Caroline hears the sound of the typewriter coming from the adjoining room and rebels against the web into which she is woven by both Georgina and the author: 'I won't be involved in this fictional plot' (117).

'EXPERIMENTAL' OR RADICAL?

The claim is often made on behalf of contemporary 'experimental' fiction that its formally radical nature involves an equally progressive set of social values. Beginning with Barthes in *Writing Degree Zero* and Robbe-Grillet in *Towards a New Novel*, an increasing number of contemporary critics have argued that realism is ideologically coercive and socially regressive. This is seen as the consequence of its assumption of shared perceptions of what 'reality' consists of, its belief in 'the innocent eye' of a monologic authorial persona, its conviction that the self is unitary and its false optimism about human history. Above all, by taking for granted its conventions of representation, realism has been seen by such critics as 'mythologizing' what is in fact cultural as natural. Thus, whatever disturbs the discourse of realism has been taken to be, *ipso facto*, 'progressive'. Waugh claims that the more fiction 'experiments . . . at the level of the sign', the more 'fundamentally' it interrogates an everyday 'reality' that is in itself structured by disguised systems of oppression. For many such theorists, according to Waugh, realism is 'the mode most threatening to full civilisation, and metafiction becomes the mode most conducive to it' (41).

This is a position that needs reconsideration because the modern British novel is usually conceived by such critics, more or less explicitly, to be less radical, politically as well as formally, than its 'experimental' counterpart abroad. The issues are complex. While taking Conradi's point, that realism has probably been the most socially critical novelistic mode over the last century as a whole (1986: 25), it is also true that in postwar Britain, at least, it became in some respects a conservative mode. If one examines the attacks made by 1950s neo-realism on the committed literature of the 1930s, it is not just the hostility to mixing art and politics that needs noting. The form of address to the reader in which these attacks are couched leaves no space for disagreement (or even interpretation), so that the (coercive) form of the attack supports the politically conservative ideas being expressed. A good example occurs in William Cooper's *Scenes from Provincial Life*:

Unfortunately it is very difficult to write about politics in a novel. For some reason or other political sentiment does not seem to be a suitable subject for literary art. If you doubt it, you have only to read a few pages of any novel by a high-minded Marxist.

(Cooper 1950: 20)

Thus while 1950s neo-realists like Snow, Cooper and Amis celebrate the freedom of their characters to make sense of or shape the world they inhabit, the role they construct for their readers is often a passive one, in which response to the text is limited by a monologic narrative voice.

The Gothic of the 1960s reverses these emphases. In many cases the characters' freedom in fact lies in discovering the degree to which they are constrained by a variety of determinants. The reader, meanwhile, is placed in a far less stable position by the formal disorientations characteristic of the genre, including the use of faulty narrators such as Martin in *A Severed Head* or Edmund in *The Italian Girl*, framing devices like the tale within the tale (in both Fowles novels), problematic 'closures', and interrogation of received ideas about character (and conventions of characterization). As with much 'experimental' fiction, these effects not only disorient but enfranchise the reader to construct the text's meaning. Just as *The French Lieutenant's Woman* produces the author within the text (thereby revealing authorship as the effect of textual practice rather than as something transcendent and prior to it), *The Magus* does the same for the reader, by merging his/her position *vis-à-vis* the events with Urfe's. Both are similarly challenged to make sense of events; both experience anxiety and exhilaration as they attempt to do so. Spark may seem an exception in this respect, but the habitually extreme detachment and irony of her authorial personae refuse interpretation on the reader's behalf. In *The Ballad of Peckham Rye*, for instance, the radically ambivalent characterization of Douglas and the equally problematic ending prevent the kind of complicity between narrative voice and reader characteristic of much postwar realist fiction.

In attempting to assess how radical 'experimental' writing really is, one should remember how much it draws on the example of modernism – often deeply suspicious of mixing politics and literature – and the French *nouveau roman*, which was a reaction against the *littérature engagée* of the existentialists. The limitations of Waugh's argument become apparent in her comments on Fowles and Sukenick respectively. She points out the contradiction between Fowles's sympathy for feminism and the reproduction within his novels of oppressive stereotypes of women (1984:126–7). By comparison, Waugh is curiously neutral when she discusses Sukenick's introduction of real acquaintances as a way of disturbing conventional narratological decorum. She cites 98.6: 'Beside the roommate is a

girl who claims to be the lover of Richard Brautigan; maybe she knows something . . . I mean here is a girl saturated with Richard Brautigan's sperm.' Comment on the tone or gender-political implications of the passage is suppressed by the desire to advance Sukenick as one of the most 'radical' recent 'experimentalists' (132).

There is no need to share the hostility of Bergonzi (1970: 210) or Alter (1975: 222-5) to certain kinds of 'experimentalism', which they interpret not as signs of renewal in the genre but of its decadence. Yet it can sometimes seem self-absorbed and obsessively formalistic. A good example of this might be Perec's *La Disparition* (1969), the result of a determination to write a whole novel without using the letter 'e'. By comparison, 1960s Gothic, though less self-consciously 'radical' at the level of form, seems a good deal more engaged with some of the decade's most troubling cultural/political issues.

There is, for instance, persistent exploration of the accelerated fragmentation of traditional class hierarchies. *The Unicorn*, *Radcliffe* and *Not to Disturb* all exploit the convention of the 'great house' in order to challenge the characteristic optimism of 1950s neo-realism that the 'classless' society was at hand. *The Collector* is perhaps the most interesting example, in terms of the focus of this chapter, for its exploration of the way in which 'culture' is a field of conflict articulating wider class tensions. Miranda's consistent attempts to 'correct' and develop Clegg's aesthetic taste are aspects of her hostility to the somewhat indeterminate class to which Clegg's windfall now affiliates him. She is at her least sympathetic when using the heroic rhetoric of World War Two, describing herself as one of 'the Few' (220), defending a tradition of 'breeding' and 'high' culture against the barbarians represented by Clegg. In the end, she loses confidence, asserting that 'there's nothing to hold back the New People, they'll grow stronger and stronger and swamp us' (242). By articulating such prejudices, Miranda loses the reader's sympathy – with the troubling consequence that she can no longer be seen simply as victim, despite the appalling ordeal that Clegg forces her to undergo.

Indeed, perhaps the most troubling insights of 1960s Gothic derive from exploration not of class, but gender relations. Murdoch and Fowles, in particular, repeatedly explore the variety of oppressions that women continued to experience in a decade that deluded itself that 'sexual liberation' offered equal benefits to men and women. The traditional motif of the imprisoned heroine is

adapted to explore some of the ways in which contemporary women are psychologically and emotionally positioned within patriarchal society. Representations of domestic or 'romantic' violence against women are common in 1960s Gothic, and constitute an important source of its horror and terror, but the principal focus of such fiction is on the more subtle gender coercion exercised by the symbolic order, especially via cultural narratives and codes. The degree to which negative images of women are mediated and reproduced by culture, in the narrow sense here of artistic heritage and practice, is an important preoccupation of 1960s Gothic. This leads to serious doubts about the status and function of culture, and a blurring of boundaries between culture and politics, which is symptomatic of the decade.

Miranda's attempt to provide Clegg with an aesthetic education is founded on the delusion that access to the 'right' kind of culture will liberate him from the destructive attitudes to women that have led to her imprisonment. Much 1960s Gothic is sceptical that any distinction can be drawn between 'high' and 'popular' culture in this respect. While the treatment of the film industry in Spark's *The Public Image* and of television in *The Collector* suggest how 'popular' culture exploits and coerces women, Angela Carter's *The Magic Toyshop* applies a similar critique to 'high' culture. Melanie's early gender identity and expectations are constructed just as much from internalizing 'attitudes' and 'poses' (1, 14) derived from painters like the pre-Raphaelites, Toulouse-Lautrec and Cranach – and writers like Lawrence – as from advertisements (2) or the 'women's magazines', the normative values of which finally coerce her housekeeper into pretending to be married.

Gothic of the 1960s like *The Unicorn*, however, demonstrates that while such cultural narratives reinforce women's oppression, they are also damaging to men. Trapped in the discursive and ideological patterns of the literature of courtly love, Effingham Cooper 'reads' Hannah as a victim so that he can become the hero of the 'spiritual adventure story' (99) that he constructs out of their circumstances. This, ironically, makes him complicit with Scottow in prolonging her imprisonment and powerfully makes the point that the idealizing tendency of the male gaze deprives its victim of freedom and autonomy just as surely as its pornographic counterpart: 'And as he sat in his office dreaming of Hannah he found himself feeling a certain strange guilty pleasure at the idea that she was, somehow, for him, shut up, reserved, sequestered' (73). But since every jailer

is in some sense a prisoner of his charge, Cooper's controlling gaze denies him the opportunity to have the very thing he apparently yearns for, a real and free relationship with Hannah.

Even the most self-consciously fictive aspects of such works are incorporated into this kind of cultural/political critique. Thus Murdoch's unicorn image does not merely draw attention to language's difficulty in registering the full presence of its referent, but makes the point that the faulty gaze of Hannah's male companions empties her of her truly complex, contingent identity. The same is true in more substantial areas like characterization. 'Experimentalism' often regards character quite patently (and finally) as no more than a product of discourse, not only on the textual level but ideologically, too. As Bradbury has suggested, 'the model of a cybernetic world has led to an art in which the human figure exists itself as a . . . role-player, a formless performer, a cardboard cut-out' (Bradbury and Palmer 1979: 203). Gothic of the 1960s, while rejecting the supremacy of the individual will celebrated in much postwar realist and existentialist fiction, usually retains some sense of its characters' independence. At one level, this is registered in the fact that the more contradictory characters like Hannah and Honor remain 'other', unconsoling inassimilable to conventional interpretative schemes. But this symbolic independence from the 'system' of text also represents the possibility of liberation from other coercive discourses; for some of the female characters, in particular, the possibility of liberation from the analogous 'symbolic system' of patriarchy.

The refusal of conventional notions of 'closure' is another example of subordination of formal 'play' to cultural/political critique in 1960s Gothic. The open-endedness of Murdoch's *A Severed Head* and the circularity of Fowles's *The Magus*, for example, deny the reader the satisfactions of resolution apparent in much realist fiction. Both novels are first-person narratives and each raises the problem of the degree to which the narrating 'I' diverges from the narrated 'I'. But this emphasizes the crucial question of the degree to which, if at all, the central protagonists have transcended their initial patriarchal vision.

In *The Magus*, for instance, it is arguable that Conchis's attempt to educate Nick Urfe has failed. On his return to London, Urfe retains traces of the patriarchal blindness identified earlier as being, perhaps, his chief limitation. The desire for revenge on Alison remains to some degree, and there are flashes of his old predatory

sexual instinct. On the other hand, Urfe has come to a truer realization of Alison's separateness and value as a human being. He is also able to relate to his landlady simply as a friend and refuses the opportunity to exploit the young Scottish bohemian Jo-Jo who mistakes her vulnerability for genuine freedom of sexual choice. *A Severed Head* is equally 'open'; Gindin argues that Martin and Honor will never be reconciled (193) and Kane is equally confident that they will (43). Honor concludes at the final meeting, "'This has nothing to do with happiness, nothing whatever'" (205). This could be interpreted as a comment on Martin's failure to attain a level of self-awareness that would make love between them possible. On the other hand it might mark her recognition that Martin has at last transcended his initial expectations of gender interaction.

CONCLUSION

The cultural/political critique provided by modern Gothic is not without its contradictions, perhaps the most deep-seated of which involves its treatment of the themes of liberation. There is a profound paradox whereby characters like Hannah, Urfe and Miranda are liberated (if they are) by extreme forms of coercion. The problem is acute in respect of gender relations. As Waugh points out, Fowles's apparent reproduction of female stereotypes that are ostensibly identified as the source and index of Urfe's limitations is troubling. Murdoch's relation to feminism is also problematic; Johnson (1987) has deplored her fiction's 'often explicit assumption of "masculinist" perspectives and values, and its curious reluctance . . . to deal directly or non-ironically with women's experience' (xi-xii). While the preceding discussion has argued that Murdoch assumes the male gaze in order to deconstruct it, it is also true that Hannah and Honor are close to the witch/Circe stereotypes traditionally used to contain the empowered woman. In the former case this cannot be ascribed to the limitations of a male narrator, since *The Unicorn* is not a first-person narrative.

There may be analogous doubts about the degree to which 1960s Gothic enfranchises the reader. Bergonzi criticizes Murdoch for surrendering to the very 'consolations of form' that 'Against dryness' warns against and suggests that her fiction remains 'far from the Tolstoyan openness to which she aspires' (1970: 47). Byatt's scepticism about *The French Lieutenant's Woman* raises similar questions about Fowles's earlier work. Its apparent 'openness' is an illusion,

she argues, because the alternative endings 'cancel each other out, rendering Fowles as arbitrary a puppet-maker as he declared his desire not to be' (1979: 28). Just as the characters are finally contained in and controlled by the text, so the reader's freedom of interpretation is similarly curtailed. Both authors are aware of the problem. Murdoch records only partial 'willingness to hand over the interpretation to the reader', and Fowles, too, realizes that the liberation he offers is limited: 'I do not think a novelist can offer freedom to his readers, however aleatory his technique' (Ziegler and Bigsby 1982: 217 and 118).

None the less, Fowles's defence of his method holds good for much 1960s Gothic, particularly in comparison with the role constructed for the reader by 1950s neo-realism. It 'suggests to the reader a possible mode of escape in terms of her or his own life and its fictions and realities. It can't, of course, offer the actual escape itself' (Ziegler and Bigsby 1982: 118). As Bigsby comments, 'The author unavoidably has his thumb in the scale, but his gestures of deconstruction, his offer to let the text go where it will, are not wholly unreal or deceptive' (113). By rejecting the monologic authority of neo-realist narrative voice, 1960s Gothic encourages plurality of meaning, enlarging the role of the reader in 'producing' the text. From a purely formal perspective, lack of 'closure' may be a convention as arbitrary as its presence, but the actual experience of reading an 'open' rather than a 'closed' text is quite different.

In other respects, too, 1960s Gothic marked a distinct break with the novelistic practice dominant between 1945 and 1960. The self-awareness and frankness of its treatment of sexuality makes the work of many of the novelists of the 1950s seem puerile in this respect, though to be fair the *Lady Chatterley* trial made the climate much more favourable for later writers. A new maturity is particularly evident in the way 1960s Gothic was able to represent 'deviant' sexuality in non-judgemental ways, as in Storey's *Radcliffe* and Carter's *The Magic Toyshop*, for example.

The use of 'popular' form enabled much 1960s writing to bridge markets and audiences (all three writers under discussion were bestsellers). It also helped undermine the authority of accepted notions of what constituted 'good' literature. The Leavises, still a dominant force in English criticism at the beginning of the 1960s, had been hostile throughout their careers towards Gothic. *Fiction and the Reading Public* (1932) railed against its 'clumsy call for pity,

shudders and so forth' (134), and *Revaluation* (1956) dismissed 'the trashy fantasies and cheap excitements of the Terror school' (134). Charlotte Brontë and Dickens were excluded from the 'great tradition' partly because their work diverged from the *Scrutiny*-derived discourse linking 'realism' to social and moral responsibility in fiction, but also for incorporating 'popular' narrative forms into their fiction – Gothic perhaps being the dominant one for both. That aesthetic canons such as these supported discriminatory, even coercive, social values is ably demonstrated by 1960s Gothic novels such as *The Collector* and *The Magic Toyshop*. In this area of debate, as well as in its admittedly problematic treatment of sexuality, gender and freedom, 1960s Gothic consistently probed at and articulated some of the central anxieties of the decade. The innovative form with which these problems were expressed bears comparison with some of the more obviously 'experimental' writing in Europe and America at the time, and may do something to counterbalance one habitual belief about British culture in the modern period, that when experiments or formal developments did appear, they were always imported from abroad.

NOTES

- 1 Jeffrey Richards's chapter in this book explores film versions of many of their novels.
- 2 Alternatives to the term 'experimental fiction' in criticism of the contemporary novel include 'the anti-novel', 'metafiction', 'the postmodern novel', 'irrealism', etc.
- 3 Recourse to 'popular' form, while a characteristic of the 1960s novel, was not, of course, exclusive to it. *The Turn of the Screw* and *The Secret Sharer* remind us that even 'high' modernism was interested in the possibilities of Gothic.
- 4 Hammer is discussed further by Jeffrey Richards in chapter 11.
- 5 A welcome exception is Randall Stevenson's chapter 'Contemporary Gothic' (Stevenson 1986), but, apart from a few lines on Spark, he focuses on writers more recent than those addressed by this chapter.

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FURTHER READING

Little has been published on the novel in the 1960s specifically, though Swinden in Pearce and Piper (1989) and Laing in Sinfield (1983) are useful starting points. Bergonzi (1970) takes a pessimistic perspective on the postwar period up to the end of the decade. There is also interesting material in Stevenson (1986). Scholes (1967), Waugh (1984) and McHale (1987) provide good discussions of 'experimental' writing in the decade. Bradbury (1977) and Bradbury and Palmer (1979) contain essays by or on the principal writers discussed in this essay. Ziegler and Bigsby (1982) provide important interviews with Murdoch and Fowles. Recommended criticism of Fowles includes Conradi (1982) and Loveday (1988); Conradi (1986) is good on Murdoch, as are Johnson (1987) and Dipple (1982); for Spark one might consult Bold (1986) and Page (1990). Kane (1988) discusses all three writers on whom this essay focuses, but is limited. Pearce and Piper place British writing in the decade in an international context.